

science advisor, James R. Killian, to convene the President's Science Advisory Committee (PSAC) to come up with a plan for a new space flight organization. Quietly considering the creation of a new civil space agency for several months, PSAC worked with staff members from Congress and quickly came forward with a proposal that placed all non-military efforts relative to space exploration under a strengthened and renamed National Advisory Committee for Aeronautics (NACA), which had been around since 1915.

Eisenhower accepted the PSAC's recommendations and sponsored legislation to expand the NACA into an agency charged with the broad mission to "plan, direct, and conduct aeronautical and space activities"; to involve the nation's scientific community in these activities; and to widely disseminate information about these activities. An administrator appointed by the president was to head the National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA). During the summer of 1958 Congress passed the National Aeronautics and Space Act and the president signed it into law on 29 July 1958.

The new organisation, NASA, started functioning on October 1, 1958, less than a year after the launch of Sputnik 1. Headed by Dr. T. Keith Glennan, its first task was the development of a human space exploration program.

Yuri Gagarin, the first man in space

Both the newly-formed NASA and the Soviets had announced their intention of putting a man into space. And with the Soviets having already won the race to send the first artificial satellite into space, they weren't about to give up their lead.

The push on the Vostok programme resulted in the successful mission of sending dogs, rats and mice aboard the Sputnik 5 into Earth's orbit and bring them back to earth safely. The green signal was given shortly after that to send a man into space.

The Russians had already started preparing candidates for the first flight. To define this new breed of pilots, they came up with the term 'cosmonauts' – or sailors of the universe. Since the mission was a furthering of the abilities that would be needed of a trained pilot, the Soviets tapped their own Air Force for candidates. A severe test of sets brought the shortlist down to six: Yuri Gagarin, Anatoli Kartashov, Andrian Nikolayev, Pavel Popovich, Gherman Titov and Valentin Varlamov. They would come to be known as the Vanguard Six. This group went extensive training in a spacecraft simulator while Sergei Korolev – the lead rocket scientist in the Soviet programme – and his team worked on the Vostok rocket. They came